

How to maximize your ERC chances

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My ERC history

Proposals

Two successful and three unsuccessful proposals.

Evaluations

On ERC Starting Grant panel 2020 and 2022. Expert reviewer for several proposals in other years.

The process

B1: five-page synopsis

- Reviewed by 3-4 generalists on evaluation panel.
- Evaluated in panel discussion.
- 25-30% success rate.

B2: 7-page proposal

- **Only read if B1 has passed.**
- Reviewed by, *in addition*, 3-4 specialist external reviewers.
- Evaluated in panel discussion after reviews and interview.
- 40-50% success rate.

Interview

- Present your proposal (online) in front of the panel.
- Answer questions, typically from 3-4 panel members, also reflecting external reviews.

What you can do

- 1 Craft an exciting and coherent research plan.
- 2 Make B1 perfect.
- 3 Make the interview perfect.

Craft an exciting and coherent research plan

Explain *what* you will do and *how*. Useful for you and makes the proposal credible.

Lot of work before funding, but worth it.

Better one big question than several loosely related projects.

In economics, 4-5 studies are promised. Best to have a common theme and an arc.

Make B1 perfect

Panel members come from different fields. You have to convince them to *want* to read your proposal.

If there is relevant connection in other fields, cite it.

Make the interview perfect

Any amount of preparation is not too much. Best use of your time.

Here you can explain your proposal and react to questions/comments. (You won't see them in advance.)

Some don'ts

Don't hide your related work

Be transparent about your own related work. If you have a paper, cite it.
Beware: reviewers will see your proposal 5-8 months after submission.

Don't strategize too much

Don't try to guess what the panel wants. It is a diverse group.
Don't spend time guessing who will be on the panel. Can even be counterproductive.

Good luck!

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Slides: koren.dev/events/2026-08-26-erc-workshop/